

AI Pedagogy Lab 1: Ethics and Academic Integrity

Executive Summary

The first AI Pedagogy focused on Ethics and Academic Integrity. 17 faculty and staff and 1 student participants engaged in structured discussions across five themes: **Learning & Assessment, Equity & Access, Transparency & Responsibility, Privacy & Data Use, and Sustainability**. A brief overview of the discussions is provided below.

Learning & Assessment

Faculty examined how AI is transforming assessment and learning in STEM, emphasizing the need to evaluate *process over product*. They discussed the employability benefits of AI literacy, but warned that over-reliance may erode core analytical and problem-solving skills. Suggestions included reflection-based assignments, student-generated questions, and low-stakes quizzes to capture growth and reasoning. Participants debated reframing academic integrity; moving from detection and punishment toward *redesigning objectives* that promote authentic engagement and critical thinking.

Equity & Access

Discussions revealed several interrelated gaps: financial, awareness, bias, and adoption; that shape how students and faculty experience AI. Faculty noted that access to premium tools can create structural inequities, and that many students remain unaware of institutionally provided tools. Verification literacy was identified as essential to combating bias, yet not all students possess it. Participants questioned who benefits from AI's rise, observing that large tech companies gain most, while marginalized students risk being left behind. Suggestions included embedding AI literacy into orientation programs and designing lessons that empower all learners to advocate for themselves.

Transparency & Responsibility

The group explored the ethics of disclosing AI use in teaching and assessment. Faculty shared that transparency can paradoxically reduce student trust. They agreed that "traffic-light" syllabus may not be working. Handling suspected misuse remains challenging, as verification demands significant time and sensitivity. Participants favored inquiry-based assignments and open dialogue over surveillance or enforcement, arguing that transparency should model intellectual honesty rather than expose vulnerability.

Privacy & Data Use

Faculty were split in their familiarity with FERPA and other privacy regulations. Participants noted that major AI vendors often collect user data for product improvement and monetization, typically without meaningful consent. Balancing privacy with personalization was described as difficult, given today's culture of oversharing. Practical suggestions included using incognito browsing, anonymizing data, and avoiding uploads of student information to public AI platforms. Several participants called for institutional policies modeled after stricter international frameworks such as GDPR and the EU AI Act.

Sustainability

Faculty acknowledged the high energy and resource demands of AI systems. While companies like Microsoft and Google aim for carbon neutrality, others remain opaque about sustainability practices. Participants agreed that, in education, AI's environmental footprint is relatively minor compared to its learning benefits. Many saw potential for AI to contribute *positively* through predictive modeling and energy optimization research. Overall, they viewed sustainability awareness as important but not a deterrent to educational use.